

William Brooks Bogle and his wife Elizabeth also arrived here from Scotland, but much later, during the early 1870s. Although Ellis Island was not yet the port of entry, their names are on a plaque there. Their son (and my grandfather) William Yates Bogle was a successful merchant in Montclair, New Jersey, highly respected in the community, and the founder of a company that became part of the American Can Company (which in turn became Primerica Corporation in 1987), large enough to be among the 30 stocks in the Dow Jones Industrial Average for 75 years.

His son, William Yates Bogle Jr., was my father. At the start of World War I—before the United States declared war—he volunteered to serve in the Royal Flying Corps and flew a Sopwith Camel. This dashing pilot, handsome to a fault, was said to resemble the then Prince of Wales, who became king of England in 1936 (before abdicating to marry “the woman I love”). My father was injured when his plane crashed, and he returned home, marrying my mother, Josephine Hipkins Bogle, in 1920.

Life was easy for the well-to-do young couple, but sadly, their first two children (twins, Josephine and Lorraine) died at birth. Their first son was my brother William Yates Bogle III, born in 1927, shortly followed by another set of twins on May 8, 1929, David Caldwell Bogle and me, John Clifton Bogle.

No Idle Hands

We were born some years after my Bogle grandfather had provided a handsome new home for the growing family in Verona, New Jersey (abutting Montclair). But the Great Crash came, and soon both my home and my father’s inheritance were gone. We moved into my mother’s parents’ house, the first of the frequent moves that were to send the struggling family up and down the Jersey coast.

So while my family began with enough—in fact, much more than enough—we soon were in difficult financial straits. (My father, having grown up surrounded by the good things of the era, lacked the determination of his father, and struggled to hold a job.) From an